THE LETHAL ELIXIR

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DENNIS ROSS

Dr. Dennis Ross
Publication

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FOREWORD

Ebola is one of the most feared and lethal infections in the world. While there is no specific treatment for Ebola, two vaccines have been developed that may mitigate the infection. Because of the multiple strains of Ebola virus, the vaccines may address only one of these strains. The disease has a 40% mortality and leads to multi-organ failure. These viruses are in the Filoviridae family, and the disease is most prevalent in Africa. If a deadly virus undergoes "gain of function" through research, it could become even more deadly. These viruses are classified as Category A bioterrorism agents by the United States Centers for Disease Control (CDC).

TABLE OF CONTENTS

CHAPTER 1 1

CHAPTER 2 7

CHAPTER 3 21

CHAPTER 4 31

CHAPTER 5 37

CHAPTER 6 41

CHAPTER 7 49

CHAPTER 8 55

CHAPTER 9 65

CHAPTER 10 73

CHAPTER 11 85

CHAPTER 12 95

CHAPTER 13 107

CHAPTER 14 121

CHAPTER 15 127

CHAPTER 16 139

CHAPTER 17 151

CHAPTER 18 165

CHAPTER 19 179

CHAPTER 20 193

CHAPTER 21 203

CHAPTER 22 215

CHAPTER 23 227

CHAPTER 24 237

CHAPTER 25 247

CHAPTER 26 253

CHAPTER 27 265

CHAPTER 28 275

CHAPTER 29 285

CHAPTER 1

Frank and Susan Lee are two ordinary Chinese Americans, or least they want you to believe they are. They approached the entrance of their dry-cleaning and laundry business, a successful establishment they had built over several years through dedication and hard work. The business had become a thriving and profitable venture, representing both their perseverance and the stability they had created for themselves. It has no debts and its customers have been very satisfied with the service being provided. No advertising is needed as the customers' word of mouth comments says it all. Come to Lees for clean clothes.

They were known by their neighbors and customers as Frank and Susan Lee, a young married couple who had not yet had children. Frank was large for an Asian. He stood about 5 feet, 9 inches tall. He was lean and blessed with a full head of hair. Like many Asians, his beard was very sparse. People guessed him to be in his early thirties. He was seen as quiet and serious. He had few contacts with anyone but his employees. They told their friends that he was strict but fair. High quality work was his standard. But he paid well and provided medical insurance, paid vacations, and sick leave. Susan, on the other hand, was a lovely bubble. She was a bit younger than Frank, stood about five and a half feet tall and was simply beautiful in a delicate way, like a piece of Ming China. Her customers enjoyed talking with her and she knew all of the customers by name and their children. Nothing was too much for her to do in making people happy.

Altogether, the Lees were a typical American couple working hard to create a future for themselves. But they were more. They were NOC's or otherwise known in diplomatic circles as Non-Official Cover. This meant that unlike

ambassadors, counsels, attaches, and other declared employees of an embassy, NOCs were on their own. In effect, they were illegal aliens subject to arrest and detention with no official protection. All nations have them, and in many places, they were subject to torture and death. Being a NOC was often a dangerous job.

For the Lees, their undercover assignment was simply to be good Americans. That is, to be "sleepers". Such agents were placed in foreign nations on long-term assignments to be called to active duty when specific jobs were required of people with no attractive backgrounds that would draw attention from police.

In preparation for this assignment, the Lees were sent to a preparatory school where they learned the American language and its customs. Their English was perfectly idiomatic. They understood baseball, football, and basketball. They ate with knives and forks while using them in the American cross-handed way.

They entered the United States using Chinese tourist passports under the names of Zhao Lee for Frank and Huan Jiao for Susan. Then, they disappeared. With new social security numbers, credit cards, licenses and all the other dirt of life, they became Frank and Susan. For several years, they continued to create a normal life history of a young couple. They moved several times from one laundry job to another that taught the cleaning craft and established their credit as frugal people who could afford eventually to buy their house and cleaning business.

Being sleepers had been a good gig. They enjoyed the American life and the well wishes of friends, neighbors, and customers… until the bell rang.

It was after closing. The customers were gone. Accounts for the day were completed. Susan noticed that Frank was particularly serious, even more than his usual demeanor.

"What's wrong, Frank? You've been tense, anxious all day."

Frank sat back in his desk chair, shook a cigarette from its package, lit it, dragged deeply, and said, “I was contacted this morning by our handler.”

Susan gasped a bit as her hands fluttered to her mouth. “After all these years. What does he want?”

“He didn’t say other than we’re to meet him tonight at his motel where we will get our instructions.”

“Oh god. What can it be?”

Frank looked at his partner and replied, “Well, hopefully, it’s only a minor errand. But it’s come. We knew this day would arrive. What’s next?

The next evening after work, Frank and Susan met their handler. They had contacted each other infrequently during the years, so it was an older man who greeted them. Samuel was his American name. No one knew his Chinese name. He was about fifty years of age, slightly paunched, and greying at the temples. He spoke English with an accent but with full command of the language.

Shaking hands, Samuel said, “Frank, Susan, it’s good to see you. I have been following the development of your laundry business and it has been good. Its resale value more than equals the money we have provided. “

Susan replied, “Samuel, the Centre’s help was a godsend, but we know now its investment must be repaid. What does the Centre want us to do? I hate to rush about this but having an operational duty after all this time is frankly stressful. We want to do it right.”

“We know that and we have all the confidence in the world for you two. It’s really very simple.”

Frank gave out a sigh of relief and Susan clapped her hands.

Samuel continued, “It’s really rather simple. You are to meet and cultivate the friendship of a young man who recently moved here to Chicago after having spent his previous career as a federal bureaucrat. His name is Jason Turley. He’s an accountant at a financial institution and may come to your shop, so making first a business contact and then a personal contact should be fairly easy.”

Frank asked, “What information do you want from him?”

Samuel answered, “Actually, we’re not going to tell you. If you don’t know, then your introduction questions will be very natural. His answers will guide you in a manner that will not raise suspicions.”

Frank shrugged and said, “OK. Sounds a bit strange, but whatever works.”

Susan asked, “How close of a friendship do you want us to create? Casual or closer.”

“You’ll get more details from us, but I believe a close relationship will be needed for us to get what we want from him. I’ll leave the details of achieving it to you but yes, close.”

The meeting lasted for another hour talking about the shop. Afterward the Lees returned home. Susan asked, “OK, Frank. Apparently, our relationship needs to be close. Reading between the lines, I suspect eventually, he’ll be providing something to us that he wouldn’t do otherwise.”

“Sounds about right. So, Miss Bubbles, that means it’s your job. I’m not Mr. Personality and a warm relationship does not fit me.”

Susan snorted, “Yes, you might say that. You’re a good man but not a bundle of charm. So, it’s up to me to charm him.”

The next several days were spent reviewing who Jason Turley was. He was not a customer but did live close to the shop. So, a flier campaign was created to attract his attention.

Several weeks went by until one day, a man of Susan's age came in with a load of men's clothing. He was a fit person with brown hair, blue eyes, and dressed in a conservation blue business suit. He had a mid-western twang to his English.

Susan asked, "May I help you sir?"

The gentleman presented a flier that offered a discount for the first load of clothing to be presented. He handed it over and asked, "This offer is still good? It's a bit out of date."

Looking at it, Susan replied, "Yes sir. Dates don't matter. It's new customers that count and we want you to be ours."

"Thank you. Here it is. A bachelor's load."

"And your name sir?"

"Jason Turley."